



Asia
China

Technology
Software & Services

Industry

Expert call

Date
17 July 2026

Industry Update

Expert call takeaways on China's AI chip market updates

Key takeaways

On July 15, we hosted an expert call with Mr. Patrick, a Senior Director of R&D at a leading domestic AI chip company, to discuss the latest demand-supply trends, competitive landscape, and technological evolution within China's domestic AI chip space. The expert believes the domestic AI chips market remains a seller's market, characterized by strong demand and manufacturing capacity as the primary binding constraint. Regarding competitive dynamics, the expert highlighted supply chain capability as the key differentiator among major Chinese developers, noting that hardware capabilities appear largely comparable. For the growth outlook, he expects to see a CAGR of over 30% for domestic shipments over the next 2-3 years.

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A seller's market with supply constraints

Total shipments reached approximately 4mn units in 2025, and the expert anticipates it to expand towards 5mn by 2026. This growth is accompanied by a significant localization trend, with the domestic share expected to rise from around 40% to over 50%. Capacity is primarily concentrated in two foundries, SMIC and Hua Hong, which are anticipated to ramp up production gradually. Having said that, the supply-demand gap will likely persist through 2026 and 2027, and the expert attribute this to existing limitations in capacity, manufacturing processes, and technology generation.

Domestic competitive landscape

Domestic AI chip vendors are categorized into four tiers based on their market presence and influence. Huawei is Tier 1. Tier 2 includes T-Head (Alibaba), Cambricon, and Kunlunxin (Baidu). Tier 3 comprises companies like Hygon and the "four little dragons" (e.g., MetaX, Moore Threads, Iluvatar, etc.). Finally, Tier 4 consists of other emerging smaller players.

Technology and system-level gaps versus global leadership

While certain domestic chips, such as Huawei's Ascend 950, is comparable to NVIDIA's H100/H200 in memory capacity, they still exhibit a lag in compute performance and overall system-level integration. Furthermore, NVIDIA's offerings extend beyond standalone accelerators to comprehensive AI-factory architectures, a holistic approach that only Huawei and T-Head are beginning to partially address domestically.

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Domestic chip performance

The domestic AI chip install base is heavily skewed towards inference workloads, with a ratio of approximately 10:1 compared to training. While current domestic chips are well-suited for inference tasks, challenges persist in effectively handling training workloads, particularly for pre-training large models.

The H20-class specifications establish the qualification benchmark for domestic AI chips, requiring adequate compute power, substantial memory capacity with high bandwidth, and rapid interconnect. Domestic players generally offer comparable hardware capabilities, with Huawei leading in compute and some vendors excelling in software compatibility. Pricing, however, varies across different market segments and product cycles.

Customer segmentation and procurement strategies

AI chip customers are segmented into two primary groups, internet companies (Cloud Service Providers or CSPs) and telecommunications/state-owned enterprises (Telcos/SOEs), each exhibiting distinct procurement priorities. Internet CSPs prioritize performance, price-performance ratios, and robust supply chain capacity, often requiring suppliers to deliver upwards of 50,000 units. In contrast, Telcos and SOEs tend to favor Huawei and other vendors, valuing innovation and the flexibility of heterogeneous deployments. The qualification process for suppliers typically involves two stages—an initial sampling/admission phase followed by rigorous procurement benchmarks—with buyers commonly adopting a multi-vendor sourcing strategy to mitigate risks.



Appendix 1

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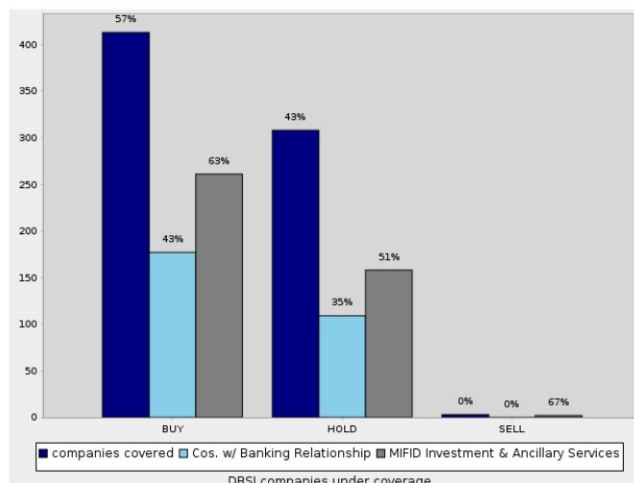
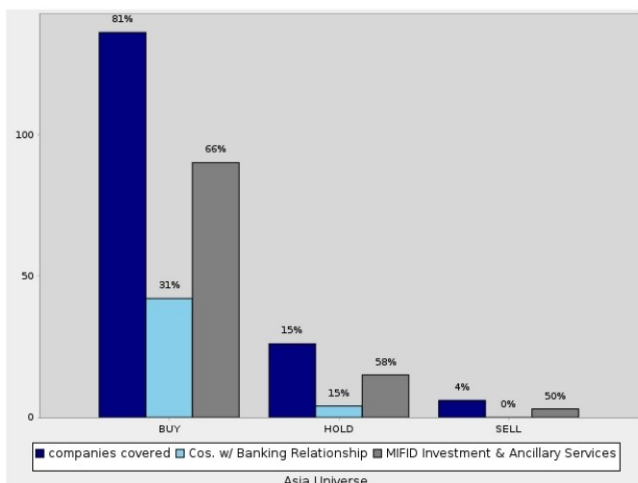


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